

Ecosystems

THE SCIENCE OF ECOLOGY STUDIES HOW ORGANISMS FORM COMMUNITIES CALLED ECOSYSTEMS.

An ecosystem is a complex set of relationships between the plants, animals, and other life forms that live in a habitat. These living things are also affected by other factors, such as weather and climate.

Niches and factors

Each species in an ecosystem occupies a niche—which means both the place and roles it carries out in the habitat. The mode of survival in any niche depends on the activity of other species in the ecosystem, such as predators looking for prey, or fast-growing algae using up the available resources. In a stable ecosystem, these influences, or factors, are in balance. If one factor changes, the rest of the ecosystem rebalances.

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This freshwater ecosystem, like all ecosystems, is affected by physical factors, such as sunlight, climate, and fire, while its living members depend on each other for food.

